

society & the arts FATHERHOOD

■ By Damayanti Datta

A crisp Saturday morning in Baroda, and around 150 men have turned up to chat and mingle. It's not just any conference. Fathers all, they have been roped in by their employer, ABB Ltd, the power and automation giant, to hear Rajalakshmi Sriram talk about fathering. Set amidst the sprawling expanse of Maneja on the outskirts of the city, everything has an ultramodern sheen. But the chic wood-and-steel décor, which usually crackles with professional energy, looks laidback and carefree today. Colourful posters hang on every corner, pushing for "child-plus-plus" attitude. Sriram, who teaches at the department of human development and family studies in MS University, belongs to the rare breed of scholars exploring the idea of fatherhood in modern India. She begins her PowerPoint slideshow: "Are You an Effective Father?" The dads fidget and cough.

Talk about catching the moment. If career moms' struggles make daily headlines, the buzz around fatherhood is getting louder. "Women's liberation has slowly but surely changed the context and substance of men's lives," points out psychoanalyst Sudhir Kakar. And dads, as the Baroda session indicates, are rising to the challenge. Expressing regret at not being able to balance work and fatherhood, they are talking about the need to be more involved with their children and trying to renegotiate their lives to allow for effective parenting. An ACNielsen survey this year revealed 74 per cent Indian men do not want work to take up all their time. And 50 per cent crave more time with family. Says Kakar, "This is one of the most striking changes associated with modernity in India"—a theme that underpins his just-released book, *The Indians: Portrait of a People*. In the West, a similar ferment saw the birth of Men's Studies a decade back, questioning traditional forms of masculinity. In India, too, a re-definition of fatherhood seems to be underway.

Overstretched

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH
Models: ANUJ DATTA and KABIR DATTA (child)

74% INDIAN MEN DO NOT WANT WORK TO BE THE ALL-CONSUMING THING IN THEIR LIVES